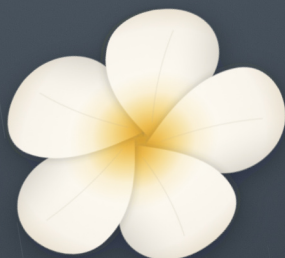


Things I Never Knew How to Say



AADITYA DIKE

Things I Never
Knew How to Say

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Love doesn't happen to beautiful people.

It happens —

and then that person becomes beautiful.

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CHAPTER ONE

27 August

Here is one more story.

Or maybe just one more day that I don't want to forget.

It started on 26 August. She messaged me asking if I was free tomorrow.

Tomorrow was 27 August, a Thursday.

Honestly, I was supposed to be at work.

But instead of saying yes or no, I asked her, "Tell me first, why?"

She told me she wanted to go and see a college where she was thinking of taking admission, and enquire about the fee structure.

I asked her if it was possible to go on Friday instead, because Friday was a holiday for my company.

She said no. "It won't work. No problem, I'll go by myself."

And that one sentence immediately made me worried.

Would she be okay going alone?

Was it really a good idea to let her go by herself?

I don't know why I worried so much.

But I did.

So I told her I'd take a half day and come with her.

Surprisingly, she agreed.

And just like that, we decided to go together.

It wasn't a date.

It wasn't supposed to be anything like that.

She just needed to go to a college. And I was going with her.

But I was happy.

Because I was going to meet her.

I was going to spend some time with her.

And that was enough to make me excited.

The whole thing was happening tomorrow, but somehow I was already waiting for the morning.

Then the sun rose.

And I was already excited. I was ready before I was even supposed to be ready.

I reached the station fifteen minutes early and started waiting for her.

And then my brain started doing what it always does.

What will she be wearing?

How will she greet me?

What will her first reaction be when she sees me?

How am I going to react?

How should I greet her?

All these thoughts were running around in my head.

And as the time got closer, my heart started beating faster. I kept looking into the distance, waiting for my eyes to catch her.

But they didn't.

She was late.

I messaged her.

No reply.

A few more minutes passed. I started getting worried that maybe she wasn't coming.

Then, after about ten minutes, she called. She had left home. She was just a little late.

And for that moment, I felt relieved.

She hadn't cancelled.

She was coming.

So I went back to waiting.

And then I saw her from a distance.

She was wearing a pink top.

And coincidentally, I was wearing a pink shirt too.

I don't know why, but suddenly butterflies started flying around in my stomach.

I couldn't even say hi.

She walked toward the station without seeing me. And I just stood there.

I had seen her.

I could have called her name.

I could have said hi.

But I hesitated.

I don't even know why.

Maybe I was nervous.

Maybe I was just too happy to see her.

After she reached the platform, she called me. I told her I was near the ticket counter and that I hadn't seen her. We talked for a while, trying to figure out where we were going to meet and which train we should catch.

And after some time, we finally found each other.

She saw me and started laughing. We were both wearing almost the same colour.

Pink.

She found it funny.

I did too.

We talked for a little while before the train arrived. I don't remember everything we talked about.

I mostly remember us smiling.

And me blushing.

Mostly me.

When the train came, we got on and sat beside each other. We talked about random things.

She was smiling.

I was watching her.

But whenever she looked at me, I immediately looked away.

I couldn't keep eye contact with her.

I don't know how people do that.

Maybe that's what happens when your favourite person looks directly at you. You can spend hours wanting to look at them without blinking, but the moment they look back at you, suddenly you don't know where to look.

And of course, she is my favourite person.

The person I could probably look at all day if I wasn't so bad at looking into her eyes.

We eventually reached our destination. We got off the train and started looking for an auto. I was struggling to find one.

She was standing there under the sun, sweating, and I started getting worried about her. I wanted to find an auto quickly. Or at least find somewhere she could stand in the shade.

Finally, I found one.

We got in and started talking again.

At one point, her hair kept coming onto my face.

I gently moved it aside.

She laughed.

And somehow, even something that small made me happy.

We reached the college.

It was huge.

And honestly, while we were there, I kept thinking that this could be a really good place for her.

At the same time, another thought quietly appeared in the corner of my heart.

What if this college becomes a reason she goes away from me?

What if she makes new friends here?

What if her life changes?

I didn't say any of that.

I just kept listening to her.

She started telling me about the course she wanted to take. Her thoughts about the college. The admission process. Everything she had been thinking about.

I listened.

And I watched her while she talked.

I liked listening to her talk about her future.

Even if a small part of me was scared of where that future might take her.

After the enquiry was done, we left. We got into another auto. She continued talking about the course and the college, and I kept listening.

After some time, it started raining.

And not the soft kind. It was heavy.

We thought we'd have to open the umbrella. But before we really had to, the rain stopped.

By the time we got out of the auto, we were back at the station.

I said, "Let's eat something."

And we started looking for a café.

I was struggling to find the right one. She was just tagging along with me, watching me struggle to figure out where we should go.

I'm pretty sure she found it funny.

And while I was walking around, another thought came into my head.

Maybe I'm wasting her time.

Maybe I'm wasting her energy.

We're just walking around looking for a café.

But she never complained.

She just stayed with me.

She kept talking to me.

And I liked that.

She never made me feel like I was disappointing her, even when I was clearly failing at something as simple as finding a place to eat.

After a few minutes, we finally found a café near the station.

There were very few people inside. It was quiet.

So we went in.

We ordered dosa. And before the food even arrived, we were already talking.

Then the dosa arrived.

I don't know why, but I was waiting for her to take the first bite.

Then I was going to eat.

But she looked at me and said, “Are you going to eat now, or should I let you eat with my hands?”

I said yes.

And she put the dosa in my mouth.

I was so happy.

I did the same thing for her.

We were both blushing.

Both smiling.

And neither of us seemed to mind how silly we probably looked.

Then she did it again.

And I let her.

After that, we finished eating and went to get watermelon juice.

And somehow, we ended up sharing the same glass.

I was blushing again.

Even when I tried to stop, I couldn't.

I was just happy.

Really happy.

For a while, I forgot about everything else.

Work.

Time.

Everything.

Then reality started catching up.

I had to go to the office.

The time was getting close.

And honestly, I didn't want to leave.

I wanted that day to keep going.

I wanted to keep sitting there.

Keep talking.

Keep walking around with her.

Just a little longer.

But eventually, we got onto the bridge.

And I handed her the chocolate I had bought for her that morning.

She was happy.

I was happy.

And I still didn't want to leave.

But she pushed me and told me to go. Otherwise, I would be late for the office.

And just like that, the time was over.

That great time.

That little piece of the day that somehow became one of the best times I've ever had.

It was over.

But that's okay.

We had already talked about meeting again soon.

So while I was leaving, I was already thinking about the next time I'd see her.

I was still blushing.

Still smiling.

Still thinking about her.

And honestly, I think I was happy for the rest of the day just because of those few hours.

Maybe it wasn't a date.

Maybe it wasn't anything special to anyone else.

It was just going to a college.

Taking a train.

Finding an auto.

Walking around.

Eating dosa.

Sharing watermelon juice.

Giving her a chocolate.

And then going back to work.

But to me, it was much more than that.

It was a day with her.

And sometimes, that's enough.

CHAPTER TWO

The Flower I Keep Seeing

She is beautiful.

She is gorgeous.

And somehow, whenever I think about her, I think about a flower.

Plumeria.

I don't know why.

Maybe because she feels like one.

She is a happy soul. Whenever I talk to her, whenever I see her, my life automatically becomes a little more colourful. I started seeing things differently after she came into my life.

There is a different sparkle in her eyes.

It always tells me that she is genuinely excited about the things she loves.

She gets angry very quickly.

She gets upset very quickly.

She gets hurt immediately.

But she is always open to talking if something is bothering her.

She is hard to convince.

She listens.

She tries to understand.

Even when she doesn't seem to understand, she tries.

And maybe that's what makes her special.

I don't even know yet what she truly loves.

I don't know what truly makes her happy.

I hope one day I get to know.

And maybe, when I do, I'll be able to give her that happiness.

I don't know why I think like this.

I don't know why I think about her so much.

Why does every thought somehow find its way back to her?

Even when I'm looking at a bright blue sky, somehow it feels like
I'm looking at her bright smile.

And when the sky isn't bright, when it's dark and raining, I still
find her there.

There is a freshness in rain.

That feeling you get when you first step into it.

Everything feels reborn.

The trees.

The leaves.

The roads.

Everything that looked ordinary suddenly looks alive again.

And somehow, when I sit there watching the rain and thinking about her, I feel the same thing.

A fresh breath of air.

A feeling that something inside me has been reborn.

But sometimes the rain feels heavy too.

Because rain reminds me that one day, everything will end.

And I'll be alone by myself.

Sometimes too much rain destroys the things we were enjoying.

And I wonder if love can do the same.

Maybe one day, too much of this feeling will destroy something inside me.

But for now, let me enjoy this rain.

Let me enjoy this sky.

Let me take in the fragrance of the flowers.

Let me enjoy these things while I can.

Because I know things don't last forever.

Things end.

The bright sky eventually becomes a dark night.

The moon you once admired, the moon whose light you held
inside your heart, eventually disappears.

The stars you once looked at thinking they would always be there
eventually fade.

The rain you once enjoyed can become a flood.

And that flood can take away everything.

The lightning strikes.

The clouds close in.

And the sound of thunder feels like something inside you is
bursting.

Maybe that's what I'm afraid of.

Not losing her today.

But losing the feeling that exists today.

The flower whose fragrance I enjoyed.

The flower I kept looking at.

The flower I dreamed of seeing bloom.

The flower I watched as if it belonged to me.

The flower I imagined taking care of.

And then one day, it falls from the tree.
It was held there for so long.
Protected by the tree.
Sheltered from the heavy rain.
Protected from the fast winds.
And then, somehow, the tree hands it over to someone else.
Maybe that flower falls for someone else.
Maybe the tree thinks I wasn't good enough.
Maybe it thinks I wouldn't have taken care of the flower the way
it did.
Maybe someone else was always meant to hold it.
And maybe that's okay.
But I know one thing.
Even after all of that, I'll still worry about that flower.
I'll still wonder whether it is safe.
I'll still wonder whether it is happy.
I'll still worry about the bright sky that once added colours to my
life.
I'll worry about the moon that was there when the night felt
dark.

I'll remember the rain that once made my heart feel fresh and reborn.

Because once something becomes a part of you, I don't think you can simply stop caring about it.

And right now, these words, these feelings, everything I'm thinking about, even the things buried somewhere deep inside my subconscious...

They all lead back to her.

The little things she says that somehow make my day.

The emojis she sends while texting.

Her asking about my day.

Her asking whether I've had dinner.

Whether I've had lunch.

Whether I'm there.

And I'll always be there.

Even when I can't.

Even when I'm about to crash out.

Even when I feel like I'm falling apart.

Somewhere inside me, the thought of her will still be there.

The worry.

The feeling.

The trust.

It will always be there for her.

Because it's not about whether she loves me.

It's about the fact that *I love her*.

Maybe that's the difference.

I'm loving her even when she isn't there.

I'm loving her even when she doesn't love me back.

I'm loving her without knowing where this will end.

Because sometimes I don't feel like *I am choosing* to love her.

It feels like something inside me already decided.

Something that doesn't want to let go.

Something that doesn't want to stop feeling this way.

Maybe that's what being in love feels like.

Or maybe I'm just calling it love because I don't know what else to call it.

Loving her feels like drinking hot, fresh coffee when you're freezing.

It feels like sitting beside a campfire on a snow-covered mountain.

It feels like eating something sweet when you've been craving sugar all day.

It feels like finding water after walking through a desert.

Maybe that's not even love.

Maybe that's just what it feels like when you're deeply in love.

Because suddenly, everything leads to her.

Every thought.

Every word I write.

Every song I listen to.

Every movie I watch.

Every time I look at the sky.

Every morning when I watch the sun rise.

Every evening when I watch it disappear.

The bright orange light hitting my retina.

The warmth I feel from the sunlight.

The reflection I see in the water.

The tree I see while walking to the office.

The cat sitting near the parking lot.

A reel I watched about love.

The picture of Radha and Krishna on my wallpaper.

The birds flying across the sky.

Everything I'm seeing suddenly seems beautiful.

I don't know what changed.

Maybe the world didn't change.

Maybe I did.

After talking to her, everything looks colourful.

Everything feels right.

The way it should be.

The way God created it.

The way everything simply is.

Even my thoughts feel different.

The feelings inside me have started to bloom.

Like a flower.

I guess this is what happens when you're in love.

When you're deeply in love with someone.

You start seeing them everywhere.

Even when they're nowhere.

And somewhere inside all of this, there is still one question.

Will she ever feel the same?

Will she ever understand?

I don't know.

But regardless of that, I just want her to feel special.

The way that flower feels special to me.

I want to protect her.

Like the tree protects the flower.

From the heavy rain.

From the fast winds.

Holding it gently.

Not letting it fall.

Not letting the things that could hurt it get close.

I want to hold her like that.

Gently.

Not controlling her.

Not owning her.

Just protecting her.

And maybe, one day, that tree will understand me.

Maybe it will trust me.

Maybe it will let me take care of that flower.

Maybe one day, it will hand over the responsibility it carried for so long.

And if that day ever comes,

I hope I'll be able to do everything that tree did.

I hope I'll understand everything that flower needs.

I hope I'll be gentle enough.

Strong enough.

Patient enough.

To take care of it.

And if that day never comes...

I hope the flower still blooms.

Even if it isn't in my garden.

CHAPTER THREE

The Flower I Chose Not to Pick

I love a girl, but I don't think she loves me back.

Maybe I am seeing things differently because I am the one who feels all of this so deeply. Maybe for her, we are just friends.

Maybe she doesn't think about me the way I think about her.

And perhaps that is why, sometimes, it feels like she doesn't care about me.

There is also everything that stands between us.

My family has its expectations. She has her own family, her own dreams, and her own fears. She is three years younger than me. I have started working and building my life, while she is still completing her degree. In another world, maybe the timing would have been different. Maybe these things wouldn't feel so heavy.

But in this world, they do.

We come from different castes. Her brother is one of my best friends. She doesn't want to ruin that friendship. She doesn't want to disappoint her parents by marrying a boy from a lower caste. And I understand that. As much as it hurts me, I understand that she has her own life to protect, her own family to think about, and her own battles that I cannot fight for her.

Sometimes it feels like everything is against me.

Even the girl I love.

Not because she is cruel. Not because she has done something wrong. But because perhaps she simply cannot see me the way I see her.

And maybe that is why a thought has slowly started growing inside me.

Maybe loving her means letting her live her life without interfering with it.

There is a quote about loving a flower so much that, instead of picking it, you leave it where it is so it can continue to bloom. I think I finally understand what that means.

Sometimes, loving someone is not about having them.

Sometimes, it is about wanting them to be happy even when their happiness doesn't include you.

Maybe she is that flower for me.

And if I truly love her, perhaps I have to let her bloom.

I don't know if I will ever stop wishing that things could have been different. Maybe in another life, we would have found each other at the right age, at the right time, without families, caste, fear, or circumstances standing between us. Maybe in another life, we would have met when everything was easier.

I sometimes wish that next life exists.

I wish that in that life, she and I find each other at the perfect time.

But for now, I have these memories.

And I want to keep them with me until my last breath.

Because there was a trip.

A simple trip with friends.

And somehow, that trip became one of the most beautiful chapters of my life.

We had only met once before everything started changing between us. It was just a friends' trip, nothing I thought would become so important to me.

For the first one and a half hours, I was on a bike. Then I got into the car for the next one and a half hours.

And she was sitting beside me.

It wasn't for very long.

But for me, it was enough to become a memory I know I will carry for the rest of my life.

I was playing romantic songs.

We sang together.

We laughed.

We enjoyed that little moment.

It was ordinary for everyone else, probably. Just friends sitting together in a car.

But for me, something about having her beside me made that moment feel different.

We took a single picture together, and I still have it saved in my Drive.

Sometimes I look at that picture and wonder how something so small could mean so much to me.

Then we met on the terrace.

I panicked.

My heart was racing so badly that I left.

I don't even know why I did that.

Maybe I was nervous because suddenly she wasn't just another girl on the trip anymore. I was becoming too aware of her.

Then we met at the pool.

I was playing with a volleyball, but my eyes were on her.

Almost the entire time.

It felt like my eyes were constantly searching for her.

Where is she?

What is she doing?

Is she okay?

Is she having fun?

I don't know when it happened, but somehow my attention always found its way back to her.

She was like a warm light to my eyes.

I didn't want her to leave my eyesight.

I was constantly trying to impress her with whatever little volleyball skills I had.

Looking back, it is funny.

I don't even know if she noticed.

But I was trying.

Then, when she was trying to get out of the pool, I held her hand and pulled her out.

I will never forget that touch.

It was only a moment.

A simple touch.

But some moments don't need to last long to stay with you forever.

After that, we started playing on the wet ground where there was mud everywhere. Everyone was playing and having fun.

Someone dragged her into the mud too.

And I immediately became worried.

I kept watching her, looking around for little things that could hurt her — small rocks, frogs, anything that might be in the way.

I wanted to be the person who would reach her first if something happened.

Maybe she never knew that.

Maybe she never noticed.

But I was watching.

I always seemed to be watching.

Then we went into the kitchen.

We were cracking jokes with my friends, and she was there, laughing and teaching me and my friends how to fry chicken.

I mostly just watched her from the side.

Then it was my turn to fry the chicken.

And I fumbled so badly.

First, I held the pakad from the wrong side.

Then my already terrible cooking skills decided to betray me completely.

She and my friends kept laughing.

And while everyone was laughing at my cooking disaster, I was mostly looking at her.

Her laugh was what I noticed.

Her smile was what I remembered.

Even when I was the joke, I didn't really mind.

Because she was laughing.

Later, we went to play games.

She was about to sit beside me, but another girl came and sat there first.

I was quite angry.

I don't even know why something so small bothered me so much.

But then I felt like she was angry too.

And strangely, that made me happy.

Maybe she had wanted to sit beside me too.

Maybe.

Or maybe I was simply hoping she did.

I don't know.

But sometimes, when you love someone, even the smallest possibility becomes a whole story inside your head.

Then came the reels.

The dancing.

The laughter.

Everyone was enjoying the night together.

I am not a dancer, so I stood in the corner, mostly watching.

Watching her.

She was enjoying herself, laughing, dancing, being completely free in the moment.

And while I was watching her enjoy herself, somehow I started enjoying the night too.

Maybe happiness can be contagious when it comes from someone you love.

Eventually, it was time to sleep.

And somehow, even the next morning, my eyes started looking for her.

After some time, they found her.

And damn...

Even after waking up, she was beautiful.

There was something about seeing her in those ordinary moments that made her even more beautiful to me.

She wasn't trying to impress anyone.

She was just being herself.

And maybe that's what I loved most.

Then we freshened up, and I went to play badminton.

She was ready in a white top and black skirt.

She looked so beautiful that I wanted to stop playing and just look at her.

But she was busy with her sister's photoshoot, so I kept playing.

Then the rain started.

She changed her outfit and got into the pool again.

And once again, my eyes found her.

I kept looking at her.

I don't know how many times I did that during the entire trip.

Maybe too many.

But I couldn't help it.

As the trip was coming to an end, something inside me already knew that this might be the last time I would see her for a while.

Maybe weeks.

Maybe months.

Maybe much longer.

I knew I would remember this trip.

I knew I would remember the moments I had with her.

I just didn't know then how important those moments would become.

And perhaps that trip was lucky in a way.

Because after that, we started talking.

Eventually, I expressed my feelings.

I told her everything.

Things I had been keeping inside.

And somehow, that trip became the reason a conversation between us even started.

A simple trip.

A car ride.

A few songs.

A few laughs.

A pool.

A hand.

A little mud.

A terrible attempt at frying chicken.

A game.

A night of dancing.

A rainy morning.

A girl in a white top and black skirt.

And a boy who couldn't stop looking at her.

Those are the memories I have.

And lately, I have been feeling that maybe this is all coming to an end.

Maybe soon, we will have to separate.

Maybe life will take us in different directions.

Maybe I will become just another chapter in her life, while she remains one of the most important chapters in mine.

And it hurts.

It hurts because I didn't want this story to end here.

I wanted more moments.

More conversations.

More trips.

More songs.

More laughter.

More chances to sit beside her.

But perhaps love isn't always about getting more.

Perhaps sometimes love is simply being grateful that you got to experience something beautiful at all.

If she cannot choose me, I don't want to force her.

If her happiness lies somewhere else, I want her to be happy.

If her family matters more to her than being with me, I cannot hate her for that.

If she only sees me as a friend, then maybe I have to accept that too.

Because I don't want to pick the flower just because I love it.

I want to leave it where it is and let it bloom.

Maybe that is the hardest kind of love.

To love someone enough to let them live freely.

To care for them without demanding that they belong to you.

To keep the memories without trying to turn them into promises.

And maybe one day, I will look back at all of this and smile.

Maybe I will remember the girl who sat beside me in a car while romantic songs played.

The girl whose hand I held for only a moment.

The girl I watched in the pool.

The girl I worried about when she was playing in the mud.

The girl who laughed while I struggled to fry chicken.

The girl I kept looking for in every room.

The girl who somehow became the warm light my eyes were always searching for.

Maybe I will remember her and be grateful.

Grateful that, even if I couldn't keep her, I got to know what it felt like to love someone this deeply.

And if this really is where our story ends, then I hope she lives beautifully.

I hope she finishes her degree.

I hope she makes her parents proud.

I hope she finds happiness.

I hope she laughs the way she did on that trip.

I hope she finds someone who makes her feel safe, loved, and understood.

And maybe, somewhere in another life, at another time, when everything is finally right...

I hope our paths cross again.

Maybe there, I won't have to let the flower go.

But in this life, if letting her bloom means walking away, then perhaps that is what I have to do.

I will carry the memories.

I will carry that picture.

I will carry that car ride, those songs, those laughs, that touch, that trip, and everything I felt.

Because some people don't stay in our lives forever.

Sometimes they stay in our hearts instead.

And perhaps she will always be one of those people for me.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Weight of Thinking About You

I have been feeling more empty with each passing day.

Whenever I talk to her, something inside me gets refilled. Even if it is just a conversation, even if it is about something ordinary, somehow that emptiness becomes quieter. But when the day is quiet, when we don't talk, I feel it again — only this time, it feels even heavier.

For the past two or three days, we haven't talked. We didn't fight. Nothing happened between us. We simply didn't talk.

And somehow, that silence has left a cold feeling in my heart that refuses to go away.

I keep thinking about her.

What might she be doing right now? What might she be thinking? Is she thinking about me too, or am I the only one sitting here thinking about her?

I don't think even a single minute has passed today without her crossing my mind.

And at some point, I started asking myself: *What am I even doing?*

Where did my motivation go?

Where did my discipline go?

Where did the vision go — the one I had for myself, the one where I was supposed to give everything I had, achieve my goals, become the person I wanted to become?

Is this love?

Is this attachment?

What is this?

I don't know.

All I know is that I am thinking about her constantly. Every second seems to carry a thought of her. I don't know what happened to me, and I don't know what will happen to me if she ever leaves.

If she decides to go away.

We are just friends. I know that. And because of that, there is always a possibility that one day she might find someone who loves her more than I do.

Sometimes I wonder what that person will be like.

Is there someone who could love her more than me?

I don't think so.

But there must be someone she will love the way I love her.

Maybe one day she will introduce that person to me.

I wonder what she would tell him about me.

Who is he? What is he to you?

Maybe we would both get jealous in our own ways.

Maybe I would think I could love her better than he could.

But then again, maybe that wouldn't matter.

I wonder if she would still keep me in her life when that person enters it.

Or would she slowly disappear from mine?

I don't know.

All I can think about is what she is doing right now.

Will I ever get the chance to be with her?

To actually be beside her?

To be with her forever?

Will that ever happen?

I don't know.

Right now, I don't even feel like I am feeling anything. I am just thinking about her.

Writing, though, feels strangely good.

It feels like I am talking to my own soul — explaining how much I care about her, how much I want her in my life, how much she means to me.

But I know something else too.

If she were suddenly sitting beside me right now, I would probably panic.

I wouldn't know what to say.

I would probably just look at her.

And keep looking at her.

Maybe my eyes would keep wondering how a person could possibly be this beautiful.

Right now, I just can't get over this emotion.

I can't get over her.

And I don't know what will happen if she decides to leave me.

On that day, I don't know what I will feel.

I don't know how I will react.

Maybe I'll cry.

Maybe I won't.

Maybe I'll stay quiet, just like I am today.

Maybe I'll write.

Not for her.

For me.

Because writing feels good.

It feels like putting a heavy weight down from my shoulders, even if only for a few minutes.

Sometimes I wonder what that day will be like.

I wonder if that day will ever come.

And if it does, I wonder who I will become afterward.

But for now, she is still here.

Not beside me.

Inside me.

In my thoughts.

In my heart.

Maybe after writing all of this, I'll ask myself, *Why am I thinking about her so much?*

I can't waste my life.

I can't spend every moment thinking about someone, right?

I have to enjoy myself.

I have to live.

But the strange thing is, even when I try to enjoy myself, somehow she finds her way into those thoughts too.

No matter how much I try to avoid thinking about her, she is always there.

Maybe the only way is to cut all the threads.

Every thread that leads back to her.

Maybe cutting them would hurt even more.

Maybe I would feel emptier than I do now.

Maybe there would be no emotions.

No feelings.

Nothing.

Just an empty void.

Like a black hole in space.

But for now, I can still talk to her.

Not whenever I want, but whenever she is free.

I can still express my feelings — not all of them, but some. The ones I can share without making them a burden on her.

I don't want her to become emotionally attached to me just because I am attached to her.

I want her to love the person she truly wants to love.

With all her heart.

Not attachment.

Not attraction.

Not affection.

Just pure love.

Because she deserves that.

And somewhere deep in my heart, I don't think I deserve to be that person for her.

Maybe because I overthink everything.

Maybe because I am the kind of person who would limit her growth.

Maybe because I would become a hurdle in her way instead of helping her move forward.

I don't even know why I think about all of this.

But then again, I am an overthinker.

I can't stop thinking.

Even when my brain feels completely exhausted.

Even when I get headaches.

Even when I desperately want my mind to be quiet.

It still finds something to think about.

And even if I somehow stop thinking, my brain and my heart find another way to bring her back into my thoughts.

I wish there were a remote control for my brain.

If there were, I would probably give it to my dearest friend.

Or maybe to her.

I'd tell them, *Please. Just turn it off for a while.*

But that's only a wish.

And some wishes are meant to remain incomplete.

It is 5:44 p.m. right now.

Only forty-five minutes before I leave for home.

And here I am, sitting by the window, writing all of this.

Maybe I won't even reach home.

Maybe I'll get into an accident.

Maybe I won't get the chance to talk to her again.

Ever.

And somehow, even in that moment, I think I would still think about her.

I would think about my friends.

My family.

My mom.

My dad.

My sister.

And her.

Maybe for the last time.

Maybe I would leave this world thinking that somehow, through these stupid words, my feelings might reach her.

To someone reading this, these might just be words.

But to me, they are everything I have left.

The person reading this might think:

How stupid is this guy?

What is he even thinking?

Why is he acting like this?

Is he mad?

Why does he think so much?

But how can I explain to them that I have always been like this?

And maybe I will always be like this.

An overthinker.

Until my last breath.

I am glad I can write all of this.

I am glad that God has given me so much of what I needed.

And I hope He gives me some of what I want too.

But I am grateful for what I already have.

I don't want to be greedy enough to ask for more.

Or maybe I do.

Maybe I'll ask for everyone's happiness.

Maybe I'll ask for everyone's dreams to come true.

Maybe I'll ask for my mom's health.

I want her to be healthy enough to attend my wedding.

Or maybe even my funeral.

She is all I have right now.

Everyone has their mother, but not everyone understands how beautiful that bond really is.

Maybe that is true love.

I have never told my mom how much I love her.

But I have shown her through my actions.

And maybe it is the same with her.

Maybe I have never been able to say everything I feel, but I hope she can see some of it in the way I care.

After my mom, I sometimes wish someone would come into my life with that same kind of love.

Not exactly the same.

Just enough.

Enough love to fill the empty space inside me.

Just true love.

I wouldn't ask anything else from her.

Not a single thing.

Just true love.

As I write these words, my hands are getting tired and red. I don't think I can write much more.

But it isn't really me writing anymore.

It is the feeling inside me forcing me to keep going.

Sitting beside the window.

Watching the sky.

Watching people.

Watching the rain.

It makes me think about how beautiful everything is.

And how much more beautiful life could be if the people you love were sitting beside you.

Sometimes I wonder whether all the things I am saying right now will remain true.

Will I still feel this way if someday I find someone who loves me with all her heart, and I love her with mine?

Will things stay the way they are now?

Or will I become a completely different person?

Will the situation change me?

Will her behaviour change me?

Will loving someone change who I am?

So many questions.

And I don't have an answer to any of them.

I only know one thing.

Right now, I am overthinking.

A lot.

A lot.

A lot.

I still wish there were a switch to turn off overthinking.

It is 5:58 p.m. now.

For today, I'm stopping.

I'm going to scroll through some reels, and then I'm heading home.

Tomorrow is Saturday.

I'll enjoy it.

I'll rest.

I'll try to live without thinking too much.

For now, I'll stop typing this shit.

The person I love has already warned me not to overthink.

And maybe she is right.

But writing this felt good.

To whoever is reading this, please don't judge me.

I'm just writing down the emotions I can't even share with anyone.

Because most people have only seen me smiling.

I'll keep smiling.

I probably always will.

But deep down, this is who I am.

An overthinker.

A person who feels too much.

And a writer who writes because sometimes writing is the only way to put the weight down.

The only way to breathe.

CHAPTER FIVE

I Just Want to Be Loved

I just want to be loved.

That's it. Nothing else.

I think if I get love, I would cross seven seas for that person. I would love that person more than I love myself. But the condition is simple: that person should love me more than I love them.

Is it too much to ask?

Maybe.

I always say that no one will take care of me, think about me, or worry about me more than my mother. And honestly, I don't just mean me. I feel like this is true for everyone.

But now I feel like no one will take care of you, think about you, or worry about you at all unless you are useful to them. Unless their needs are being fulfilled. Unless they are getting some benefit from you. Unless you are convenient for them.

Today, people fake everything.

Every emotion they show. Every word they say. They lie.

And I just hate lies.

Why do people even lie?

Why do people break the trust of someone who trusted them
with their whole heart?

Why?

I really feel like I'm walking among people who wear masks and
costumes. They are so different on the inside. They are not who
they pretend to be, and maybe they aren't even who they want to
be.

They are just selfish.

They want attention. They want all the love a person has to offer.
And once they have taken all of it, once they feel like they have
had enough, they go away.

They leave you.

And they move forward like nothing ever happened.

Why do people act selfish?

Why don't they think about the people who care about them?
The people who love them? The people who worry about them?

Why?

Or is it normal to just think about yourself? To become selfish and do only what you want? To act like none of it matters? To feel nothing for the other person?

Sometimes I wish I could have become like them.

Maybe then I wouldn't have to suffer this much.

I wouldn't have to get hurt.

I wouldn't have to tear up like I am right now.

I can't bear this any longer.

I feel so much for the people who are closest to me. I care about them. I worry about them. I love them so much that they probably can't even imagine it.

But why don't they understand that?

Why do they think this is normal?

And now, again, I think I am being too harsh on myself.

Why was I even born in this generation, where it feels like people don't care about each other?

Or why did I become like this?

This emotional fool.

No.

I'm a joker in this generation.

I'm blinded by love, and I can't see the real things right in front of me. I only see the things that love allows me to see. The good

things. The things I want to believe in. The things I want to keep safe and happy.

Sometimes I think maybe, in my next life, I'll be born like these people.

People who don't care.

People who are selfish.

People who only think about themselves.

Maybe then I wouldn't get hurt like this.

Or maybe I would just prefer not to be born again.

Because in this cruel world, it feels like you have only two choices.

Either you become cruel,

or you suffer and get hurt every minute.

I'm not angry.

I'm just frustrated.

I genuinely don't understand why people don't realize these things. How can someone fake their emotions? How can someone fake caring about another person?

I genuinely don't know.

When I care about someone, I genuinely care about them.

When I think about them, I genuinely want to know how their day went. I genuinely want to know if they are doing well in their life.

Whatever I do, I do it with my whole heart.

I don't fake anything.

And I don't think I'll ever fake anything.

Not until I die.

No matter how people treat me.

No matter how much they use me.

No matter how much it hurts me.

No matter how much it destroys me.

I'll stay kind.

I'll love the people I love.

I'll still try to make them happy.

Because that's who I am.

And that's how my mom and dad raised me.

CHAPTER SIX

The Love I Could Never Explain

It is just another random day at work.

People are talking. Phones are ringing. Screens are glowing.

Everyone seems busy with their own lives.

And somehow, in the middle of all of it, I am thinking about her again.

I don't even remember when it became this constant.

Not a single second seems to pass without her crossing my mind.

Not a single day has gone by without me thinking about her.

Sometimes it's something she said. Sometimes it's a memory.

Sometimes it's a small thing that reminds me of her.

And sometimes there is no reason at all.

She is simply there.

In my thoughts.

In the quiet moments.

In the spaces between everything else.

And here I am, sitting at work, pretending to be busy with my day while my heart is somewhere else entirely.

With her.

I don't know if she will ever understand how much I love her.

Maybe she never will.

Maybe she will never know how many times I have thought about her when she wasn't there. How many little moments I have replayed in my head. How many imaginary conversations I have had with her. How many futures I have quietly created in my mind without her ever knowing.

Maybe one day she will find these words.

Maybe she will read them and laugh.

Maybe she will feel nothing.

Maybe she will wonder why I felt so deeply.

Maybe she will never even know that these words existed.

And perhaps that's okay.

Because some feelings are so enormous that they don't need an audience.

Sometimes it's enough that *I know*.

I know how much she means to me.

I know how genuinely I have loved her.

I know that I didn't love her because I wanted something from her.

I loved her because somewhere along the way, she became important to my heart.

A mother can feel when her child is hurting without being told. I wish I could somehow make her feel the depth of what exists inside me in that same way.

Not explain it.

Not convince her.

Just let her feel it for one moment.

Because words seem too small for something this big.

She is my first true love.

I have never loved anyone the way I have loved her.

And maybe that's why it feels so different.

There was a warmth in loving her.

A kind of warmth I had never experienced before.

It made ordinary moments feel important.

A conversation.

A laugh.

A shared secret.

A stupid little memory.

A moment of happiness.

A moment of sadness.

The times we cried.

The things we told each other.

The moments when neither of us had to pretend to be okay.

Somewhere inside all of those moments, I built a little world.

An imaginary world.

A world where I could see everything we hadn't lived yet.

The places we hadn't gone.

The memories we hadn't made.

The conversations we hadn't had.

The ordinary mornings.

The difficult nights.

The laughter.

The arguments.

The making up.

The growing old.

A whole life that existed nowhere except inside my imagination.

And somehow, I lived so many moments there.

Moments that never actually happened.

Maybe that's the cruelest part of loving someone.

You can build an entire life with them in your mind while they are living a completely different life in reality.

I know she sees me as a friend.

And maybe that's all I am to her.

I know I cannot force someone to love me.

And I don't want to.

Love shouldn't be forced.

It should happen naturally.

It should be something two people choose.

Something that grows between them without one person having to beg the other to feel it.

So if she doesn't feel what I feel, then I have to accept that.

Even if accepting it hurts.

Even if some part of me keeps wishing things were different.

There were times when I felt jealous too.

I hated hearing her mention other boys' names.

I hated that strange feeling in my chest when I felt like someone else might be getting a part of her that I secretly wished was mine.

And whenever I felt she was hiding something from me, my mind would immediately start wondering why.

Maybe I was wrong sometimes.

Maybe I wasn't.

But I never liked the idea of lies.

I hate lies because trust means too much to me.

If I give someone my trust, I give it completely.

And with her, I gave more than trust.

I gave her pieces of me I don't think anyone else has ever had.

I gave her my honesty.

My vulnerability.

My memories.

My fears.

My happiness.

My sadness.

My faith in her.

My heart.

Everything.

And I only hope that the things we shared will remain somewhere safe inside her heart too.

Because those moments belonged to us.

The conversations.

The tears.

The laughter.

The things we told each other that nobody else needed to know.

I hope she keeps them there.

Not because I want to control what she does with them, but because they were pieces of a world that existed between two people.

Her and me.

And I hope she never breaks the trust I placed in her.

Because if that trust breaks, something inside me will break with it.

Not because she owes me love.

She doesn't.

But because when you show someone your entire heart, you hope they will hold it gently.

I wish she could find someone she truly loves.

And strangely, I mean that.

I hope someday she meets someone who makes her feel what she has never felt before.

Someone who makes her understand how beautiful love can be.

How pure it can be.

How much care can exist inside it.

How much a person can worry about another person's happiness.

I hope that person loves her deeply.

I hope he makes her laugh.

I hope he stays when life becomes difficult.

I hope he understands the parts of her that she doesn't show everyone.

I hope he protects her heart.

I hope they fall deeply in love with each other.

And I hope she is happy.

Because even though I couldn't be the person she chose, I don't want her to go through life without finding the love she deserves.

And maybe, somewhere along the way, I will find mine too.

Not just me.

I hope everyone does.

Every person who has ever sat alone wondering whether they will ever be loved the way they love.

Every person who has given more than they received.

Every person who has loved quietly.

Every person whose heart has been broken by someone they never wanted to lose.

I hope they all find someone.

Because despite all the pain it has caused me, love is still the most beautiful thing I have ever experienced.

It is also the most painful.

Because sometimes loving someone means realizing you may have to let them go.

And letting go of the person you love most can feel like losing an entire world.

Maybe that's what I am grieving.

Not only her.

But the life I imagined with her.

The world I created.

The future that existed inside my head.

The version of us that was never given the chance to exist.

Maybe that feeling will never come back.

And honestly, perhaps I don't want it to.

Because I don't want another person to replace what she gave me.

That warmth was special because *she* was special.

I don't want to erase it.

I want to remember it.

I want to remember what it felt like to love someone for the first time with everything I had.

Even if it hurt.

Even if it wasn't returned in the same way.

Even if someday I have to accept that she was never meant to be mine.

I will still be grateful that, for a while, my heart knew what it was capable of feeling.

And sometimes I wonder...

Maybe there is another world somewhere.

A world where things happened differently.

A world where she and I found each other at the right time.

A world where the love between us was mutual.

Where we lived all those imaginary moments I created.

Where we travelled together.

Where we laughed until our stomachs hurt.

Where we cried and held each other through the difficult days.

Where we grew old together.

Where neither of us ever had to wonder whether the other felt the same.

Maybe in that world, she chooses me.

And maybe I choose her.

Again and again.

Every day.

Without hesitation.

And maybe, in that world, we are deeply, hopelessly, peacefully in love.

So deeply in love that neither of us ever wants to walk away.

Maybe God has another world waiting for me somewhere.

A world where the love I couldn't have here becomes the life I get to live there.

But here, in this world, on this ordinary day at work...

I am just sitting here.

Thinking about her.

Loving her quietly.

Knowing she may never understand how much she meant to me.

And somehow, despite all of it,

I am still grateful.

Because she taught my heart something I had never known before.

What it feels like to love someone with everything you have.

And maybe that's enough for this chapter.

Maybe not the ending I wanted.

But perhaps one day, when I look back at this part of my life, I won't only remember the pain.

I'll remember that once, there was a girl who made my ordinary days feel extraordinary.

A girl who became my first true love.

And a boy who, for the first time, discovered just how deeply his heart could love.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Will She Ever Understand?

There is something I have been thinking about while writing all of this.

Will she ever understand?

Will she ever understand what all of these words actually mean?

Will she read them one day and feel what I was feeling while writing them?

Or will she think this is cringe?

Will she think I am crazy for writing all of this?

Will she wonder, *Why does this guy want me so badly?*

Maybe she will.

And sometimes I am scared of something else too.

What if she actually does become mine?

What if, one day, she says yes?

What if I finally get the person I have wanted for so long?

Will that period of wanting her ever end?

Will I eventually become comfortable?

Will the excitement disappear?

Will the things I am doing now become effortless and boring?

Will there be a day when having her beside me feels normal
instead of something I am grateful for every second?

I don't know.

And maybe that is one of the things I am most afraid of.

Because right now, I constantly feel like I need to make sure she is
happy.

But will that ever be enough for her?

Will I ever be enough for her?

Can I actually be someone's reason for happiness?

Or will I somehow ruin the things she already has?

That thought scares me.

Because it is easy to imagine loving someone.

It is harder to imagine being responsible for their happiness.

And sometimes I wonder whether I am capable of carrying
something like that.

It is so difficult for my heart.

So difficult for my soul.
To hold this feeling.
To conserve it.
To keep it alive.
The feeling of sitting beside her.
The feeling of having her by my side.
The feeling of wanting her to love me.
Wanting her to love me the way I love her.
But then another thought comes.
She probably won't.
Maybe she never will.
Maybe she can't.
Because whatever I feel for her cannot be measured.
It isn't something she can understand just by reading these words.
She can read every sentence I have written.
She can know every thought I have had.
She can know every fear I have ever carried.
And still, she may never understand the actual depth of it.
Because it isn't that simple.
It is the care I have for her.

The things I think about when she isn't even there.

Her future.

Her safety.

Her happiness.

Her life.

I don't just think about these things sometimes.

I think about her.

Only her.

Since the time she came into my life, I have never looked at another girl in a romantic way.

And I don't think I will while she is still somewhere in my life.

Maybe that sounds crazy too.

I don't know.

But it is the truth.

And right now, while I am writing this, I am still checking my phone.

Again.

Did she reply to my good morning message?

Did she wake up?

Maybe she is awake but hasn't checked her phone.

Maybe she checked her phone but not that account.

Maybe she saw the message and decided to reply later.

Maybe.

Maybe.

Maybe.

I use that word so much.

Maybe.

But perhaps every “maybe” is just another form of my overthinking.

Every possibility becomes a story.

I imagine every version of what could be happening.

And somehow, for a few moments, I live inside those possibilities.

But real life doesn't work that way.

Things don't happen exactly as I imagine them.

They never will.

The story inside my head has no limits.

Reality does.

And still, my heart doesn't stop.

It keeps thinking about her.

Only her.

Sometimes I wonder what would happen if she said yes.

If somehow she chose me.

If somehow we stayed together.

Would I be able to make her happy?

Would I be enough?

Would I be able to give her the life she dreams about?

Would I be able to make her feel loved every single day?

Would I be able to give her the life she deserves?

Sometimes I get tears in my eyes just thinking about it.

Because even her saying yes scares me.

Not only because I wonder whether I deserve that yes.

But because I wonder whether I could actually give her everything that comes with it.

And then there is the other answer.

No.

That one hurts for a completely different reason.

Because if she says no, then I won't be there.

Not beside her.

Not in her world in the same way.

I won't be able to protect her.

I won't be able to know how she is doing.

I won't be able to be there in the little moments.
She will still exist in my world.
But I may no longer exist in hers.
And that thought hurts more than I know how to explain.
But for now, we are friends.
And that is enough for me.
At least for now.
I want to be with her while I can.
I want to talk to her while I can.
I want to know about her life while she still lets me be a part of it.
Maybe one day she will find the boy she wants.
Maybe one day someone else will become the person she chooses.
And maybe then, this will end.
Not just the conversations.
Not just the possibility.
The feeling itself.
Maybe I will have to kill it.
And then kill it again when it comes back.
Because I know myself.
It will come back.

It will grow again.

And I will have to keep killing the same emotion until perhaps one day I meet someone who truly loves me.

If that person exists.

I hope that person finds me at the exact right time.

Because if she finds me too late, after I have spent years destroying everything inside myself, I don't know what will be left.

Maybe I will become emotionless.

Maybe I will stop feeling things the way I am supposed to.

And that wouldn't be fair to the person who eventually wants me beside her either.

She would deserve someone who can love her fully.

Not someone who spent so long killing his own feelings that he no longer knows how to feel.

Sometimes I wonder what I have become.

How miserable I have become.

And maybe this is only the beginning.

Maybe if I keep going like this, I won't even be the same person anymore.

But I have found one way to keep myself from becoming completely miserable.

Writing.

Only this.

Putting these thoughts somewhere outside my head.

Writing them down before they grow too large.

Because if I stop writing, I am afraid they will stay inside me.

And then they will hurt.

They will hurt so badly that maybe I won't know how to recover.

So I keep writing.

Maybe these words are useless.

Maybe they have no purpose.

Maybe whoever reads this will laugh at me.

Maybe they will call me crazy.

Maybe they will abuse me for writing something this emotional
about someone who isn't even mine.

And maybe they will be right.

Because what use is any of this?

What does anyone get from reading my feelings?

Nothing.

Absolutely nothing.

And honestly, I hope no one finds this.

But if someone does find it, I hope they don't read it like just
another chapter.

Because this isn't just another chapter.

This is what I am feeling right now.

Exactly right now.

This is me.

Sitting at this random desk.

Looking out of the window.

Looking at the sky.

Thinking about her.

Writing about her.

Checking my phone.

Waiting for a notification from her.

And somehow every word I write comes back to her.

Every thought.

Every question.

Every fear.

Every hope.

Everything.

And the one question that refuses to leave me is still the same.

Will she ever understand?

Will these words make her understand how much I care about her?

How much I love her?

Will she understand what I am trying to say between all these words?

Will she understand that this isn't about wanting to own her?

It isn't about controlling her.

It isn't about taking her freedom.

It isn't even about getting something from her.

It is simply that somewhere along the way, she became someone my heart started caring about more than I know how to explain.

And now I don't know how to make it stop.

Maybe I don't want it to stop.

Maybe I am just scared of where it will take me.

And still...

I am checking my phone.

Again.

Maybe there will be a notification from her.

Maybe not.

But for some reason, that one small notification still has the power to make my entire day feel different.

And maybe that is the most embarrassing part of all.

That after everything I have written...

After everything I have understood...

After all the responsibilities waiting for me...

After all the thoughts about my career, my family, my future, and
the person I want to become...

My heart can still become quiet for just one reason.

Her name appearing on my screen.

*Love doesn't happen to beautiful people.
It happens —
and then that person becomes beautiful.*

Most of this was written at a desk by a window, in the middle of an ordinary working day.

By someone who checks the phone each morning and waits for one notification. Who reached the station fifteen minutes early. Who still has one picture from a trip saved in a Drive folder.

It is about a girl, and a plumeria, and the rain. About overthinking every message. About family and responsibility. About wanting to be loved, and choosing to stay kind anyway. About loving someone enough to let them bloom, even if it isn't in your garden.

It is not a story with an ending.

It is the things he never knew how to say.

